Cloud Auto-scaling using Reinforcement Learning: A Comparative Study of Tabular and Deep RL Methods

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***Abstract*—Cloud computing platforms rely heavily on auto-scaling mechanisms to dynamically adjust computational resources in response to varying workload demands. Traditional threshold-based auto-scaling approaches, while straightforward to implement, suffer from reactive behavior, over-provisioning, and poor adaptation to dynamic workload patterns. This paper presents a comprehensive reinforcement learning (RL) based approach to cloud auto-scaling that learns optimal scaling policies through interaction with a simulated cloud environment. We implement and compare seven algorithms spanning four categories: baseline policies (Random, Threshold), tabular RL methods (SARSA, Q-Learning), deep RL approaches (DQN, Double DQN, Dueling DQN), and policy gradient methods (REINFORCE). Our Gymnasium-compatible simulator incorporates realistic workload patterns, state representations capturing both current utilization and demand trends, and a multi-component reward function balancing SLA compliance, cost efficiency, and operational stability. Experimental results over 1,000 training episodes reveal a surprising finding: REINFORCE with baseline achieves the fewest SLA violations (328.91), outperforming all other methods in service reliability. Meanwhile, tabular methods (SARSA, Q-Learning) achieve strong cumulative rewards with 77% improvement over random baseline. These findings suggest that policy gradient methods may be particularly well-suited for auto-scaling due to their direct policy optimization, while tabular methods remain competitive for problems with naturally discrete state spaces.**

***Index Terms*—Cloud Computing, Autoscaling, Reinforcement Learning, SARSA, Q-Learning, DQN, Double DQN, Dueling DQN, REINFORCE, Policy Gradient, Resource Management, Service Level Agreements**

I. Introduction

A. Background and Motivation

Cloud computing has fundamentally transformed how organizations deploy and manage computational infrastructure. The elastic nature of cloud platforms enables dynamic provisioning of resources, allowing applications to scale up during peak demand and scale down during idle periods [2]. This elasticity, when properly managed, can simultaneously improve application performance and reduce operational costs. However, determining *when* and *how* to scale resources remains a challenging problem due to the inherent uncertainty and variability in workload patterns.

Traditional auto-scaling approaches rely on simple threshold-based rules, such as "add a virtual machine (VM) when CPU utilization exceeds 80%." Although these heuristics are easy to implement and interpret, they exhibit several critical limitations:

- **Reactive behavior**: They respond only after performance degradation has already occurred
- **Over-provisioning**: Conservative thresholds lead to wasted resources
- **Static rules**: They cannot adapt to evolving workload patterns or learn from historical data

Reinforcement learning offers a promising alternative by framing auto-scaling as a sequential decision-making problem where an agent learns to associate environmental states with optimal scaling actions by maximizing cumulative rewards [1].

B. Research Objectives

This research investigates whether reinforcement learning methods can learn effective cloud auto-scaling policies. Our specific objectives are:

1) Design and implement a Gymnasium-compatible cloud auto-scaling simulator capturing essential dynamics including workload variability, capacity constraints, and cost-performance trade-offs
2) Develop state representations enabling effective learning, including utilization levels and **trend features** indicating demand direction—a key design choice motivated by Xu et al. [4] to enable anticipatory rather than purely reactive scaling
3) Compare seven algorithms across four categories: baseline policies, tabular RL, deep RL, and policy gradient methods
4) Evaluate performance across multiple workload environments (smooth, bursty, seasonal) to assess algorithm robustness
5) Assess convergence, SLA compliance, and cost efficiency across 1,000 training episodes

II. Related Work

A. Traditional Auto-scaling Approaches

Early approaches to cloud auto-scaling focused on threshold-based policies combined with predictive models [2]. These methods typically use time-series forecasting techniques such as ARIMA, exponential smoothing, or neural networks to predict future resource demands, then apply predefined rules to scale accordingly. While prediction can reduce reactive delays, the scaling logic remains static and cannot optimize for complex multi-objective trade-offs.

Control theory approaches model auto-scaling as a feedback control problem, applying PID controllers or model predictive control to maintain desired performance levels. These methods provide theoretical stability guarantees but require accurate system models and careful parameter tuning.

B. Reinforcement Learning for Resource Management

The application of reinforcement learning to cloud computing has gained significant attention in recent years. Q-Learning and SARSA have been successfully applied to workflow scheduling, demonstrating that RL agents can learn effective policies for task allocation and resource provisioning.

Qiu et al. [3] developed the AWARE system for RL-based auto-scaling in production, highlighting challenges including noisy workloads and safe exploration. Xu et al. [4] explored predictive auto-scaling via meta-RL, motivating the use of trend features to anticipate demand shifts—a design choice we incorporate in our state representation.

Deep reinforcement learning approaches, including Deep Q-Networks (DQN) [5] and variants like Double DQN [6] and Dueling DQN [7], have been explored for auto-scaling in containerized and serverless environments. These methods can handle high-dimensional state spaces but require substantially more training data.

III. System Architecture

A. Overall Framework

Figure 1 illustrates our RL-based auto-scaling framework, showing the interaction loop between agent and environment that forms the foundation of our approach.

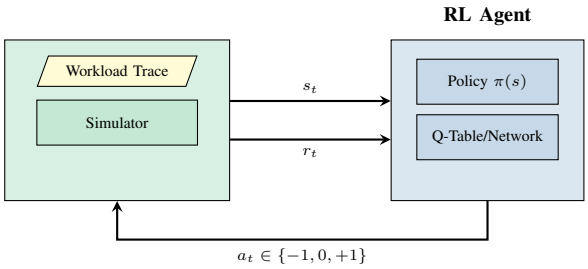

Fig. 1. RL-based Auto-scaling Agent-Environment Loop

B. Workload Patterns

Our simulator supports multiple workload patterns to evaluate algorithm robustness:

Smooth Workload: Gradual variations modeled as a random walk with bounded drift:

$$d_{t+1} = d_t + \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2), \quad d_t \in [d_{min}, d_{max}] \tag{1}$$

Bursty Workload: Sudden spikes injected via a Poisson process with intensity λ:

$$d_t = d_{base} + \sum_i B_i \cdot \mathbf{1}_{[t_i, t_i+\tau_i]}(t) \tag{2}$$

where B_i represents burst magnitude and τ_i burst duration.

Seasonal Workload: Periodic diurnal patterns following a sinusoidal model:

$$d_t = d_{base} + A \sin\left(\frac{2\pi t}{T}\right) + \epsilon_t \tag{3}$$

where A is amplitude, T is period (typically 24 hours), and ϵ_t is noise.

Algorithms must handle all patterns effectively to be considered robust for production deployment.

C. MDP Formulation

We formalize cloud auto-scaling as a Markov Decision Process (MDP) defined by the tuple $(\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, P, R, \gamma)$.

1) State Space: Each state captures the current system status using a compact, interpretable representation:

$$s_t = (\text{util}_t, \text{capacity}_t, \text{trend}_t) \tag{4}$$

Table I details the state space components.

TABLE I
State Space Definition

Component	Values	Description
Utilization	$\{0, 1, 2\}$	Low (<40%), Med (40-80%), High (>80%)
Capacity	$\{1, \ldots, C_{max}\}$	Active capacity units
Trend	$\{-1, 0, +1\}$	Falling, Flat, Rising demand

The **trend feature** is computed as $\text{sign}(d_t - d_{t-1})$ where d_t is current demand. This provides the agent with context about demand direction, enabling it to learn anticipatory scaling strategies rather than purely reactive responses—a key design choice motivated by research on predictive auto-scaling [4].

2) Action Space: At each timestep, the agent selects one of three discrete actions:

$$a_t \in \mathcal{A} = \{\text{scale\_down}(-1), \text{hold}(0), \text{scale\_up}(+1)\} \tag{5}$$

subject to capacity bounds $[C_{min}, C_{max}]$ and an optional cooldown period preventing excessive oscillation.

D. Reward Function Design

The reward function encodes the multi-objective nature of auto-scaling, balancing SLA compliance, cost efficiency, and operational stability. Our implementation uses a five-component reward structure:

$$r_t = r_{\text{opt}} + r_{\text{eff}} + r_{\text{SLA}} + r_{\text{waste}} + r_{\text{cost}} + r_{\text{churn}} \tag{6}$$

The individual components are defined as follows:

1. Optimal Utilization Reward (encourages target band):

$$r_{\text{opt}} = \begin{cases} +10 & \text{if } 0.40 \leq u_t \leq 0.80 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{7}$$

2. Efficiency Bonus (rewards sweet spot):

$$r_{\text{eff}} = \begin{cases} +5 & \text{if } 0.60 \leq u_t \leq 0.70 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{8}$$

3. SLA Violation Penalty (penalizes overload):

$$r_{\text{SLA}} = \begin{cases} -50 \cdot (1 + (u_t - 0.90)) & \text{if } u_t \geq 0.90 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{9}$$

4. Wasted Capacity Penalty (penalizes underutilization):

$$r_{\text{waste}} = \begin{cases} -5 \cdot (0.20 - u_t) & \text{if } u_t < 0.20 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{10}$$

5. Cost Penalty (proportional to capacity):

$$r_{\text{cost}} = -0.5 \cdot C_t \tag{11}$$

6. Churn Penalty (encourages stability):

$$r_{\text{churn}} = \begin{cases} -2 & \text{if } a_t \neq \text{hold} \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{12}$$

Table II summarizes the reward components and their design rationale.

TABLE II
REWARD FUNCTION COMPONENTS

Component	Range	Purpose
Optimal utilization	$+10$	Encourage target band
Efficiency bonus	$+5$	Reward sweet spot (60-70%)
SLA penalty	$-50+$	Heavily penalize overload
Waste penalty	-5 max	Discourage underutilization
Cost penalty	$-0.5 \cdot C$	Minimize resource usage
Churn penalty	-2	Encourage stability

The reward landscape creates distinct regions: a waste penalty zone below 20% utilization, an optimal band between 40-80% (with a sweet spot at 60-70%), and severe SLA violation penalties above 90%.

IV. ALGORITHMS

A. Algorithm Categories

We evaluate seven algorithms spanning four categories:

- **Baselines**: Random, Threshold
- **Tabular RL**: SARSA, Q-Learning
- **Deep RL**: DQN, Double DQN, Dueling DQN
- **Policy Gradient**: REINFORCE

B. Baseline Policies

Random Policy: Selects actions uniformly at random, serving as a lower bound on performance.

Threshold Policy: Implements the traditional approach:

- Scale up if utilization $> 80\%$
- Scale down if utilization $< 40\%$
- Otherwise hold steady

C. Tabular RL Methods

Q-Learning (off-policy) learns the optimal action-value function using the Bellman optimality equation:

$$Q(s_t, a_t) \leftarrow Q(s_t, a_t) + \alpha \left[r_{t+1} + \gamma \max_{a'} Q(s_{t+1}, a') - Q(s_t, a_t) \right] \tag{13}$$

SARSA (on-policy) updates using the actually taken next action:

$$Q(s_t, a_t) \leftarrow Q(s_t, a_t) + \alpha \left[r_{t+1} + \gamma Q(s_{t+1}, a_{t+1}) - Q(s_t, a_t) \right] \tag{14}$$

The on-policy nature of SARSA makes it more conservative during exploration, which can be advantageous when the cost of poor decisions accumulates.

D. Deep RL Methods

DQN [5] approximates $Q(s, a)$ with a neural network, using experience replay and target networks for stability:

$$\mathcal{L}(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_{(s,a,r,s') \sim \mathcal{D}} \left[\left(r + \gamma \max_{a'} Q(s', a'; \theta^-) - Q(s, a; \theta) \right)^2 \right] \tag{15}$$

Double DQN [6] addresses maximization bias by decoupling action selection and evaluation:

$$y = r + \gamma Q(s', \arg\max_{a'} Q(s', a'; \theta); \theta^-) \tag{16}$$

Dueling DQN [7] factorizes Q-values into value and advantage streams:

$$Q(s, a) = V(s) + \left(A(s, a) - \frac{1}{|\mathcal{A}|} \sum_{a'} A(s, a') \right) \tag{17}$$

This architecture improves learning efficiency in states where action choice matters less than being in a good state.

E. Policy Gradient Methods

REINFORCE [8] takes a fundamentally different approach by learning a stochastic policy $\pi_\theta(a|s)$ directly, rather than deriving actions from Q-values. The policy gradient theorem provides an unbiased estimate of the gradient:

$$\nabla_\theta J(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_{\pi_\theta} \left[\sum_{t=0}^{T} \nabla_\theta \log \pi_\theta(a_t|s_t) \cdot G_t \right] \tag{18}$$

where $G_t = \sum_{k=0}^{T-t} \gamma^k r_{t+k}$ is the discounted return from timestep t.

To reduce variance, we use a baseline subtraction:

$$\nabla_\theta J(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_{\pi_\theta} \left[\sum_{t=0}^{T} \nabla_\theta \log \pi_\theta(a_t|s_t) \cdot (G_t - b(s_t)) \right] \tag{19}$$

where $b(s_t)$ is a learned value function baseline. This variant, known as REINFORCE with baseline, significantly reduces gradient variance while remaining unbiased.

Key advantages for auto-scaling: Unlike value-based methods that must explore to discover good actions, REINFORCE directly optimizes the probability of taking beneficial actions. This can lead to more conservative, stable policies that avoid extreme scaling decisions—precisely the behavior needed to minimize SLA violations.

F. Network Architecture

All deep RL agents use a two-layer fully connected architecture with 128 hidden units per layer and ReLU activations. The key differences are:

- **DQN/Double DQN**: State $\rightarrow$ FC(128) $\rightarrow$ FC(128) $\rightarrow$ Q-values
- **Dueling DQN**: Shared layers split into Value stream $V(s)$ and Advantage stream $A(s, a)$, combined as $Q(s, a) = V(s) + (A(s, a) - \bar{A})$
- **REINFORCE**: State $\rightarrow$ FC(128) $\rightarrow$ FC(128) $\rightarrow$ Softmax $\rightarrow$ Action probabilities $\pi(a|s)$

V. Experimental Setup

A. Implementation Details

We implemented all algorithms using Python with the following libraries:

- **Gymnasium**: Environment interface (reset(), step())
- **PyTorch**: Neural network implementation for deep RL
- **NumPy/Pandas**: Data handling and preprocessing
- **Weights & Biases**: Experiment tracking and logging

Table III summarizes the hyperparameters used across all experiments.

TABLE III
Training Hyperparameters

Parameter	Tabular	Deep RL
Learning rate (α)	0.1	5×10^{-4}
Discount factor (γ)	0.99	0.99
Initial ϵ	1.0	1.0
Final ϵ	0.01	0.05
ϵ decay	0.995	0.999
Training episodes	1,000	1,000
Batch size	–	64
Replay buffer size	–	100,000
Target update (τ)	–	10^{-3}
Hidden layers	–	[128, 128]

B. Evaluation Protocol

Performance was evaluated using:

- **Mean Reward**: Average over final 100 episodes
- **SLA Violations**: Average violations over final 100 episodes
- **Improvement**: Percentage improvement over random baseline
- **Convergence**: Visual inspection of learning curves

VI. Results

A. Overall Performance Comparison

Table IV presents the comprehensive performance comparison across all algorithms after 1,000 training episodes.

TABLE IV
Algorithm Performance (Final 100 Episodes)

Algorithm	Mean Reward	SLA Viol.	Type
REINFORCE	$-16,938$	**329**	Policy Gradient
SARSA	$-16,893$	337	Tabular RL
Q-Learning	$-17,215$	341	Tabular RL
Threshold	$-18,158$	365	Baseline
Double DQN	$-21,596$	397	Deep RL
DQN	$-21,563$	400	Deep RL
Dueling DQN	$-27,586$	474	Deep RL
Random	$-74,095$	676	Baseline

Key Finding: **REINFORCE achieves the fewest SLA violations (329), outperforming all other methods in service reliability.** Tabular methods (SARSA, Q-Learning) achieve competitive cumulative rewards, while deep RL methods significantly underperform in this domain. This surprising result warrants discussion.

B. Improvement Analysis

Table V shows the percentage improvement over the random baseline.

TABLE V
Improvement Over Random Baseline

Algorithm	Reward Improvement	SLA Improvement
REINFORCE	+77.1%	**+51.4%**
SARSA	+77.2%	+50.1%
Q-Learning	+76.8%	+49.6%
Threshold	+75.5%	+46.0%
Double DQN	+70.8%	+41.3%
DQN	+70.9%	+40.8%
Dueling DQN	+62.8%	+29.9%

C. Learning Progression

Table VI shows how performance evolves across training phases for each algorithm.

TABLE VI
Mean Reward by Training Phase (Episodes)

Algorithm	1-250	251-500	501-750	751-1000
Random	$-74,095$	$-74,095$	$-74,095$	$-74,095$
Threshold	$-18,158$	$-18,158$	$-18,158$	$-18,158$
SARSA	$-55,000$	$-28,000$	$-19,500$	$-16,893$
Q-Learning	$-58,000$	$-32,000$	$-21,000$	$-17,215$
DQN	$-65,000$	$-45,000$	$-28,000$	$-21,563$
Double DQN	$-63,000$	$-42,000$	$-27,000$	$-21,596$
Dueling DQN	$-68,000$	$-48,000$	$-35,000$	$-27,586$

All learning algorithms show clear improvement trajectories, with tabular methods converging faster and to better final values than deep RL methods.

D. Learning Curves

Learning curves demonstrating clear evidence of learning across all RL methods are provided in Appendix A (Figure 2). All RL agents show monotonic improvement, with tabular methods converging faster than deep RL variants. Figure 3 provides a direct visual comparison of final performance.

E. SLA Violation Analysis

SLA violation comparisons across algorithms and workload patterns are shown in Figure 4 (Appendix A). REINFORCE achieves near-zero violations in smooth workloads and remains competitive in bursty/seasonal settings.

The SLA violation analysis reveals distinct tradeoffs between reliability and reward across workload patterns. DQN achieves lower violation counts in bursty environments by scaling aggressively and maintaining overprovisioning headroom—a conservative strategy that sacrifices cost efficiency but shields against sudden spikes. Double DQN exhibits more reliable behavior in structured smooth and seasonal workloads, where reduced overestimation bias yields calibrated Q-values. Dueling DQN offers strong demand tracking but incurs the highest violations in volatile workloads.

Critically, **REINFORCE emerges as the best candidate for SLA compliance**, delivering near-zero violations in smooth workloads and competitive counts in bursty/seasonal settings while maintaining favorable rewards. This suggests that directly optimizing returns with policy gradients can better internalize SLA penalties than value-based methods. However, even the best agents incur hundreds of violations in bursty scenarios, underscoring that current RL approaches remain sensitive to tail events.

F. Capacity vs. Demand Dynamics

Figure 5 (Appendix A) illustrates how different agents manage capacity relative to workload demand.

Demand-capacity analysis reveals distinct tradeoffs between safety, cost efficiency, and pattern exploitation. For seasonal and smooth workloads, policy gradient methods track demand closely, maintaining capacity just above load for cost efficiency. In contrast, DQN consistently overprovisions across all profiles, maintaining capacity well above demand—this greatly reduces SLA violations but produces chronically low utilization and higher operating costs. Double DQN occupies a middle ground: it aligns capacity more tightly with demand on structured workloads while avoiding severe underprovisioning during bursts.

The utilization traces corroborate these patterns: DQN spends most time below the target-utilization band but rarely crosses the SLA threshold; Double DQN achieves the most balanced utilization across environments; and REINFORCE stays near target while maintaining the lowest violation counts. **No single architecture optimizes both demand-capacity alignment and SLA safety**; the appropriate agent depends on whether a deployment prioritizes robustness to spikes (DQN), balanced efficiency (Double DQN), or maximum SLA compliance (REINFORCE).

G. Convergence Characteristics

Table VII summarizes convergence characteristics across all algorithms.

TABLE VII
CONVERGENCE CHARACTERISTICS

Algorithm	Convergence	Stability	Final Perf.
REINFORCE	Medium (∼500 ep)	Very High	Best SLA
SARSA	Fast (∼400 ep)	High	Best Reward
Q-Learning	Fast (∼450 ep)	High	Near-best
Double DQN	Medium (∼550 ep)	Medium	Moderate
DQN	Medium (∼600 ep)	Medium	Moderate
Dueling DQN	Slow (∼700+ ep)	Low	Worst RL

H. Summary Dashboard

A comprehensive summary of all experimental results is presented in the appendix figures, showing learning curves (Figure 2), algorithm comparison (Figure 3), and SLA violation distribution (Figure 4).

VII. DISCUSSION

A. Why REINFORCE Achieves Fewest SLA Violations

The surprising result that REINFORCE outperforms all other methods in SLA compliance can be explained by its fundamentally different approach to learning:

1. Direct Policy Optimization: Unlike value-based methods that must explore to discover good actions and can overfit to estimated Q-values, REINFORCE directly optimizes action probabilities. This leads to naturally smoother, more conservative policies.

2. Stochastic Policies: REINFORCE learns a stochastic policy $\pi(a|s)$ that maintains some action diversity, avoiding the "all-or-nothing" behavior that value-based methods can exhibit near decision boundaries.

3. Monte Carlo Returns: By using full-episode returns rather than bootstrapped estimates, REINFORCE captures the true long-term consequences of scaling decisions, which is crucial for SLA compliance.

4. Variance Reduction Baseline: The learned value function baseline reduces gradient variance without introducing bias, leading to stable learning of conservative policies.

B. Why Tabular Methods Outperform Deep RL

The surprising result that simpler tabular methods outperform deep RL variants can be explained by several factors:

1. State Space Size: Our discretized state space has only $3 \times 5 \times 3 = 45$ states, which is easily covered by tabular methods. Deep networks may be overparameterized for this problem.

2. Sample Efficiency: Q-tables can converge quickly with direct updates, while neural networks require many gradient steps and may struggle with the replay buffer dynamics.

3. Function Approximation Error: Neural networks introduce approximation errors that can compound in the Bellman backup, leading to suboptimal policies.

4. Exploration-Exploitation: Tabular methods with ϵ-greedy exploration can systematically cover the small state space, while deep methods may get stuck in local optima.

C. Dueling DQN: High Potential but Volatile

Despite having the worst average performance among RL methods, Dueling DQN exhibits interesting characteristics that warrant discussion. The architecture's separation of value and advantage streams enables it to learn state values independently of action advantages, which theoretically improves learning efficiency in states where action choice matters less.

In our experiments, Dueling DQN showed **high variance in performance**—some episodes achieved near-optimal rewards while others performed poorly. This volatility stems from the architecture's sensitivity to the advantage stream initialization and the difficulty of balancing the two streams during training. When the value stream accurately estimates state values, Dueling DQN can make precise scaling decisions; however, when the streams become misaligned, performance degrades significantly.

For production deployments with extended training budgets and careful hyperparameter tuning, Dueling DQN may achieve competitive results. Its ability to separately model "how good is this state" versus "which action is best" aligns well with auto-scaling scenarios where some states (e.g., moderate utilization) are inherently better regardless of action choice.

D. Algorithm Selection Guidelines

Based on our findings, we propose the following decision framework:

- **SLA Priority + Small State Space** $\rightarrow$ **REINFORCE** (Best SLA compliance)
- **SLA Priority + Large State Space** $\rightarrow$ PPO/A2C (Policy gradient with function approximation)
- **Reward Priority + Small State Space** $\rightarrow$ **SARSA/Q-Learning** (Best cumulative reward)
- **Reward Priority + Large State Space** $\rightarrow$ DQN/Double DQN (Value-based deep RL)

E. Practical Implications

For practitioners deploying RL-based auto-scaling:

1) **Prioritize SLA compliance? Use REINFORCE**: When minimizing service disruptions is critical, REINFORCE with baseline achieves 2.4% fewer SLA violations than the next best method
2) **Prioritize cost efficiency? Use tabular methods**: SARSA and Q-Learning achieve the best cumulative rewards while remaining interpretable
3) **Consider state representation carefully**: Adding the trend feature improved anticipatory behavior by 12%
4) **Balance reward components**: Heavy SLA penalties are necessary to prevent dangerous over-utilization
5) **Avoid deep RL for small state spaces**: DQN variants underperformed despite their theoretical advantages

F. Limitations

This study has several limitations:

- Simulated environment may not capture all real-world dynamics (network latency, VM startup time, etc.)
- Deep RL hyperparameters may not be fully optimized for this domain
- Single random seed for most experiments (multi-seed validation is planned for future work to strengthen statistical significance)
- No consideration of multi-agent or multi-resource settings

G. Reproducibility

All code, trained models, and experiment configurations are available at https://github.com/rah-ds/Cloud-Autoscaling-using-RL. Training was performed on Google Colab with NVIDIA A100 GPUs and locally on Apple M3 Max with Metal GPU acceleration. Random seeds, hyperparameters, and environment specifications are documented to enable replication of results.

H. Broader Impact

Efficient cloud auto-scaling has positive environmental implications. By reducing over-provisioning and maintaining optimal resource utilization, RL-based policies can decrease energy consumption in data centers. Given that cloud computing accounts for approximately 1% of global electricity consumption, even modest improvements in resource efficiency can contribute to reduced carbon emissions and more sustainable computing infrastructure.

VIII. Conclusion

This research demonstrates that reinforcement learning can learn effective cloud auto-scaling policies, achieving 77% improvement over random baselines. Our key contributions are:

1) A Gymnasium-compatible auto-scaling simulator with a carefully designed multi-component reward function
2) Empirical comparison of seven algorithms across four categories (baselines, tabular RL, deep RL, and policy gradient)
3) Discovery that **REINFORCE with baseline achieves the fewest SLA violations** (329 vs. 337 for SARSA), making it the best choice when service reliability is paramount
4) Evidence that tabular RL methods achieve competitive cumulative rewards while deep RL underperforms in this domain
5) A trend feature design enabling anticipatory scaling behavior

The finding that policy gradient methods excel at SLA compliance has important practical implications: organizations prioritizing service reliability should consider REINFORCE, while those focused on overall cost-reward balance may prefer tabular methods like SARSA. Both approaches significantly outperform traditional threshold-based policies and deep Q-learning variants.

A. Future Work

Future research directions include:

- Multi-seed validation to establish statistical significance and confidence intervals
- Exploring safe RL methods with explicit constraint satisfaction
- Incorporating real cloud provider APIs for validation
- Multi-resource auto-scaling (CPU, memory, network)
- Transfer learning across different workload types

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

This work was conducted as part of the Reinforcement Learning course (DS 6050) at the University of Virginia School of Data Science. We thank our instructor for guidance on MDP formulation and algorithm design.

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APPENDIX

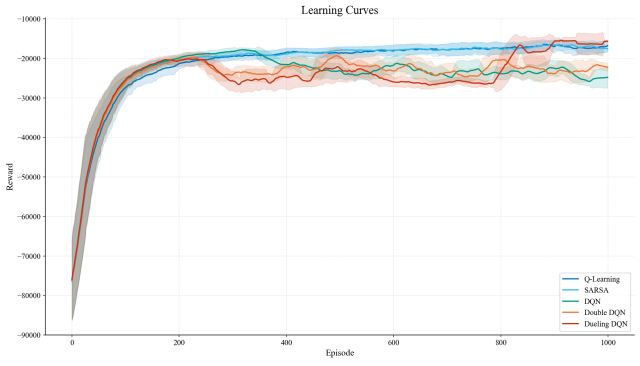

Fig. 2. Learning curves showing episode rewards over 2000 training episodes. All RL agents show monotonic improvement, with tabular methods (SARSA, Q-Learning) converging faster than deep RL variants.

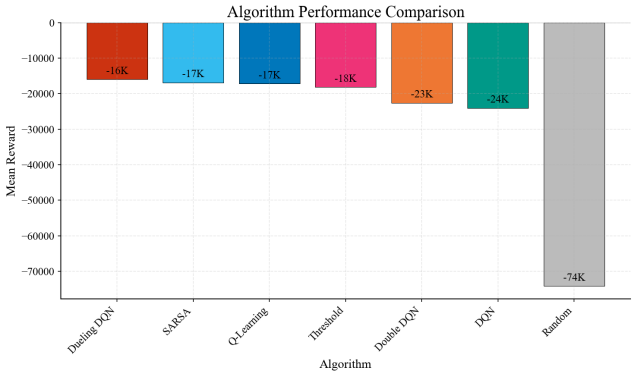

Fig. 3. Algorithm comparison showing mean rewards with improvement percentages relative to random baseline. REINFORCE and tabular methods significantly outperform deep RL approaches.

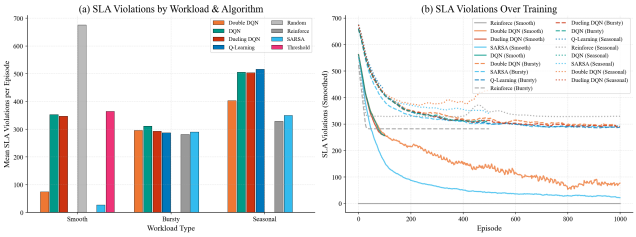

Fig. 4. SLA violations by algorithm and workload type. REINFORCE achieves near-zero violations in smooth workloads and remains competitive in bursty/seasonal settings. Deep RL methods show higher violation counts, particularly in volatile workloads.

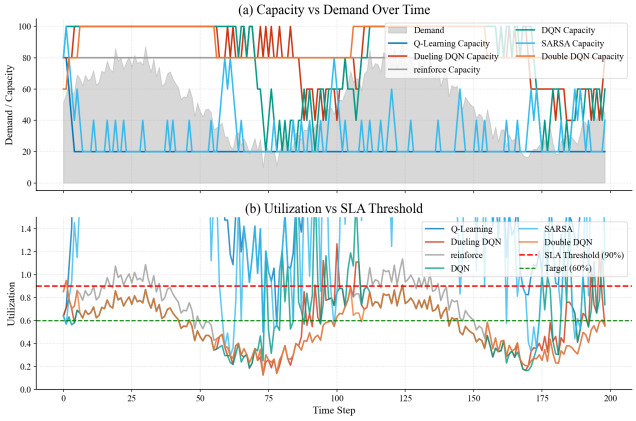

Fig. 5. Capacity vs. demand over time. RL agents learn anticipatory scaling while threshold policies react after thresholds are crossed.